

8 June 2003

Dear Jen,

Everyday is the same day. I am stuck in a rut and that is impossible to escape. Yesterday I requested to go out on patrol with the scouts in the evening. Usually the nights are slow around here so I didn't imagine that it would be a problem. Instead of agreeing, I got a long-winded spiel from both battle captains about how I need to make time within my schedule to do anything outside of my regular TOC duty. I think this is a convenient excuse, especially since they have a third person to help them out—and will probably both be relieved of this duty shortly. Anyhow, I was not allowed to go out in the evening. Instead, I stayed here and answered a total of maybe 5 radio calls. Great. At 2 in the morning, when my shift ended, I went out on three hours of night patrol with Horse 2, one of our scouts, just to break the monotony of my job. The trip was worth my time and I will discuss it later.

Today, however, I had a similar run-in. Since I went out until 5 am, I did not make it to the gym this morning. I was hoping to squeeze in a twenty minute workout while everyone else was in the Battalion Update Brief. I told Sergeant Sneed that I would come upstairs around 5 pm and get a quick lift. Captain Hamilton immediately interjected. Again, he started on how this was my job and that it was unacceptable for me to go anywhere during my shift. What the hell happened to being a Lieutenant, an officer, or simply being able to make an insignificant decision regarding my own personal affairs. I even volunteered to give up my dinner—which I usually end up eating here in the TOC—in order to work out. The answer was again “No.” I am frustrated. I cannot believe how little autonomy I am given as an officer. I have never worked in a place—besides the Red Cross—where I have been so limited.

Anyhow, the end result of all this is simple. I have less autonomy than a basic private. It is hard to describe my level of frustration. I just want to go to a place where I can yell and scream and break something. I have worked in this office for three straight months and I understand the work load and the process. I know when we have to be a maximum staffing and I know what needs to get done and when. All I ask is to have the chance to allocate personnel and work independently. The more I need to be heard, the more I am ignored.

Well, I was going completely stir crazy yesterday so I went on patrol with the scouts at 2 in the morning. I was hoping to find a little excitement. At 2:30, Sergeant Mayo showed up with his patrol, ready to take the “rookie policeman” out with them. I had tried to clean my weapon despite not having the right equipment. I gathered up my Kevlar helmet and vest and I was ready to go, hoping that something exciting would happen.

We pulled out of the compound and onto the streets of the city. I didn't say anything, but just soaked up all the sights. The main streets of Baghdad were empty at this hour. All the traffic lights were red and the entire city looked like a ghost town. We drove past the